# Angela's Ashes

## By Frank McCourt

**FRANK:** It's my turn. The confession box is dark and there's a big crucifix hanging over my head. I can hear a boy mumbling his confession on the other side. I wonder if there's any use trying to talk to the Angel on the Seventh Step. I know he's not supposed to be hanging around confession boxes but I feel the light in my head and the voice is telling me, Fear not.

The panel slides back before my face . . . *(to Priest)* Bless me, Father, for I have sinned. This is my First Confession.

**PRIEST:** Yes, my child, and what sins have you committed?

**FRANK:** I told a lie. I hit my brother. I took a penny from my mother's purse. I said a curse. . . I, I listened to a story about Cuchulain and Emer.

**PRIEST:** Surely that's not a sin, my child. After all we are assured by certain writers that Cuchulain turned Catholic in his last moments.

**FRANK:** 'Tis about Emer, Father, and how she married him.

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*(whispering)* She won him in a pissing contest. *(to audience)* There is heavy breathing. The priest has his hand over his mouth and he's making choking sounds and talking to himself, Mother o' God.

**PRIEST:** *(trying to control is laughter)* Who, who told you that story, my child?

**FRANK:** Mikey Molloy. He read it in a book, Father.

**PRIEST:** For your penance say three Hail Mary's, and three Our Fathers.

**FRANK:** Father, was that the worst sin? Am I the worst of all the boys, Father?

**PRIEST:** No, you have a long way to go. God bless you, my child.

## INTRODUCTION

*Crossed-eyed Mikey Molloy is eleven years old. He knows about the female body and "Dirty Things in General." Mikey tells Frank a story of Irish mythology about the great Cuchulain's wife, Emer, who was the "champion woman pisser of Ireland." Uh – oh – And thus begins the story of Frank McCourt's first confession and communion.*

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**FRANK:** First Communion Day is the happiest day of your life because of The Collection and James Cagney at the Lyric Cinema. The night before I was so excited, I couldn't sleep till dawn. I'd still be sleeping if my grandmother hadn't come banging at the door.

**GRANDMOTHER:** *(knocking at the door)* Get up! Get up! Get that child outa the bed! Happiest day of his life an' him snorin'.

**FRANK:** I ran to the kitchen. I took off [my] shirt and she pushed me into a tin tub of icy cold water. They dressed me in my black velvet First Communion suit with the white frilly shirt, the short pants, the white stockings, the black patent leather shoes.

**GRANDMOTHER:** Come here till I comb your hair. Look at that mop, it won't lie down. *(she spits on his head to control the hair)* You didn't get that hair from my side of the family. That's that North of Ireland hair you got from your father. That's the kind of hair you see on Presbyterians. If your mother had married a proper decent Limerickman you wouldn't have this standing up, North of Ireland, Presbyterian hair. *(she spits on his head again)*

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**FRANK:** Grandma, will you please stop spitting on my head.

**GRANDMA:** If you have something to say, shut up. A little spit won't kill you. Come on, we'll be late for the Mass.

**FRANK:** We ran to the church. My mother panted along behind with Michael in her arms. We arrived at the church just in time to see the last of the boys leaving the altar rail where the priest stood with the chalice and the host. *(Priest assumes glaring stance) (Frank opens his mouth to receive communion and speaks with his mouth full)* Then he placed on my tongue the wafer, the body and blood of Jesus. At last, at last! *(look of surprise as the wafter sticks)* It stuck! I had God glued to the roof of my mouth! I could hear the master's voice:

**PRIEST:** Don't let the host touch your teeth for if you bite God in two you'll roast in hell for eternity.

**FRANK:** I tried to get God down with my tongue *(tries to dislodge the wafer)*

**PRIEST:** *(hissing)* Stop that clucking and get back to your seat.

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**FRANK:** God was good. He melted and I swallowed Him and now, at last, I was a member of the True Church, an official sinner.

When the Mass ended, there they were at the door of the church, my mother and my grandmother. They each hugged me and told me it was the happiest day of my life. They cried all over my head and after my grandmother's contribution that morning my head was a swamp. *(to Mom)* Mam, can I go now and make The Collection?

**GRANDMOTER:** No. You're not making no collection till you've had a proper First Communion breakfast at my house. Come on.

**FRANK:** We followed her. She banged pots and rattled pans and complained that the whole world expected her to be at their beck and call. I ate the egg, I ate the sausage, and when I reached for more sugar for my tea . . .

**GRANDMOTHER:** *(slapping his hand)* Go aisy with that sugar. Is it a millionaire you think I am? An American?

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Is it bedecked in glitterin' jewelry you think I am? Smothered in fancy furs?

**FRANK:** The food churned in my stomach. I gagged. I ran to her backyard and *(he throws up).* Out she came.

**GRANDMOTHER:** Look at what he did. Thrun up his First Communion breakfast. Thrun up the body and blood of Jesus. I have God in me backyard. What am I goin' to do? *(thinking)* I'll take him to the Jesuits!

**FRANK:** She dragged me through the streets of Limerick. She told the neighbors and passing strangers about God in her backyard. She pushed me into the confession box. *(to the Priest)* In the name of the Father, the Son, the Holy Ghost. Bless me, Father, for I have sinned. It's a day since my last confession.

**PRIEST:** A day? And what sins have you committed in a day, my child?

**FRANK:** I overslept. I nearly missed my First Communion. My grandmother said I have standing up, North of Ireland, Presbyterian hair. I threw up my First Communion breakfast. Now Grandma says she has God in her backyard and what should she do?

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**PRIEST:** *(struggling to control his laughter)* Ah … ah … tell your grandmother to wash God away with a little water and for your penance say one Hail Mary and one Our Father. God bless you, my child.

**FRANK:** Grandma and Mam were waiting close to the confession box.

**GRANDMOTHER:** Were you telling jokes to that priest in the confession box? *(gives him a slap on the back of the head)* If 'tis a thing I ever find out you were telling jokes to Jesuits I'll tear the bloody kidneys outa you. Now what did he say about God in me backyard?

**FRANK:** He said wash Him away with a little water, Grandma.

**GRANDMOTHER:** *(thinking)* Holy water or ordinary water?

**FRANK:** He didn't say, Grandma.

**GRANDMOTHER:** Well, go back and ask him. *(pushing him back into the confessional)*

**FRANK:** Bless me, Father, for I have sinned, it's a minute since my last confession.

**PRIEST:** A minute! What is it now?

**FRANK:** *(embarrassed)* My grandma says, Holy water or ordinary water?

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**PRIEST:** Ordinary water, and tell your grandmother not to be bothering me again.

**FRANK:** *(exiting the confessional)* Ordinary water, Grandma, and he said don't be bothering him again.

**GRANDMOTHER:** Don't be bothering him again! That bloody ignorant bogtrotter!

**FRANK:** Can I go now and make The Collection? I want to see James Cagney.

**GRANDMOTHER:** You can forget about The Collection and James Cagney because you're not a proper Catholic the way you left God on the ground. Come on, go home.

**MOTHER:** Wait a minute. That's **my** son. That's my son on his First Communion Day. He's going to see James Cagney.

**GRANDMOTHER:** *(throwing her hands up)* Take him then to James Cagney and see if that will save his Presbyterian North of Ireland American soul. Go ahead. *(she exits in disgust)*

**FRANK:** We met Mikey Molloy on Barrington Street. He asked if I was going to the Lyric and I said I was trying.

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**MIKEY:** Trying? You don't have money? That's all right. I'll get you in. I'll create a diversion.

**FRANK:** What's a diversion?

**MIKEY:** I have the money to go and when I get in, I'll pretend to have the fit and the ticket man will be out of his mind and you can slip in when I let out the big scream. *(demonstrates the scream)* I'll be watching the door and when I see you in, I'll have a miraculous recovery. That's a diversion. That's what I do to get my brothers in all the time.

**MOTHER:** Oh, I don't know about that, Mikey. Wouldn't that be a sin and surely you wouldn't want Frank to commit a sin on his First Communion Day.

**FRANK:** Mikey said if there was a sin it would be on his soul, and he wasn't a proper Catholic anyway so it didn't matter. He let out his scream and I slipped in. The ticket man was so worried over Mikey he never noticed! *(triumphant grin that turns to horror as he realizes he has sinned again. He arrives at church the next day and enters the confessional)*

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*(to the Priest)* In the name of the Father, the Son, the Holy Ghost. Bless me, Father, for I have sinned. It's a day since my last confession.

## SOURCE INFORMATION

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